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Investigating the drivers for social commerce in social media platforms: Importance of trust, social support and the platform perceived usage

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ABSTRACT

This study sheds light on the drivers of social commerce in social media platforms. First, it explores the perceived characteristics of the social commerce vendor and investigates their influence on users' trust. Second, it tests the influence of trust and the platform perceived usage (using the Unified Technology Acceptance and Use of Technology Model 2) on social commerce intent. Data from a survey of Instagram users, within the Golf Corporation Council countries, were collected online. Results show that reputation and price advantage have the strongest influence on trust, although those effects are weakened by habits. Contrary to expectations, social interactions with the social commerce vendor decrease trust. Similarly, product differentiation reduces trust. Nevertheless, this effect is negatively moderated by social support. Perceived ease of use of the platform, facilitating conditions, hedonic motives and habits increase social commerce intent. The findings of this research offer some insights on the mechanisms through which the s-vendor characteristics influence social commerce intent on social media platforms. Findings help businesses better understand the social commerce landscape and improve their marketing strategies.

1. Introduction

The use of social media has seen a tremendous increase in the last few years. Social media platforms have played a major role in content marketing by sharing information and opinions about products and services (Cha, 2009). Users are motivated by fulfilling emotional, social, functional, self-oriented and relational needs (Davis et al., 2014). These social media platforms are based on openness, cooperation, co-creation, trust and commitment between users (Constantinides, 2014).

Progressively, the use of social media evolved and many social media-based businesses have emerged, giving rise to social commerce. Social Commerce refers *to "the delivery of e- commerce activities and transactions via the social media environment, mostly in social networks and by using Web 2.0 software. Thus, social commerce is a subset of e-commerce that involves using social media to assist in e-commerce transactions and activities*" (Liang and Turban, 2011, p. 6). It enables businesses to reach global and distant customers and to build a good relationship with them (Park and Kim, 2014).

In spite of the infatuation for social commerce, the use of social media by businesses is still in its nascence. Only a few social commerce vendors (s-vendors) have made an excellent business out of it. The lack of face-to-face interactions has resulted, indeed, in customers' suspicion of the truthfulness of the s-vendor and an increase of the perceived risk of online shopping (Kaiser and Müller-Seitz, 2008). The rapid growth of social media has made it also challenging to follow the trend and understand the operating of the different social media platforms to perform business tactics. For instance, there is a lack of information on how the perception of the platform usage, influences the purchase behavior, whereas there are endless social media platforms for different usages and unique characteristics (Hajli et al., 2017; Peters et al., 2013). Thus, there is an urgent need to understand social commerce shoppers' perceptions, trust and outcomes while considering the specificity of the social media platform.

In the literature review, it has been shown that trust plays a crucial role in stimulating online purchases (Wang et al., 2016; Cyr et al., 2010; Quelch and Klein, 1996). However, modest effort is made regarding the users' perceptions in a social commerce context and impact on trust. Much research has focused on social support and importance for social commerce (Lu et al., 2016; Zhu et al., 2016; Hajli, 2014a, 2014b; Liang et al., 2011). Nevertheless, few studies have shed light on the s-vendor characteristics perception (Kim and Park, 2013) and none has considered the platform perception by users mainly the acceptance to

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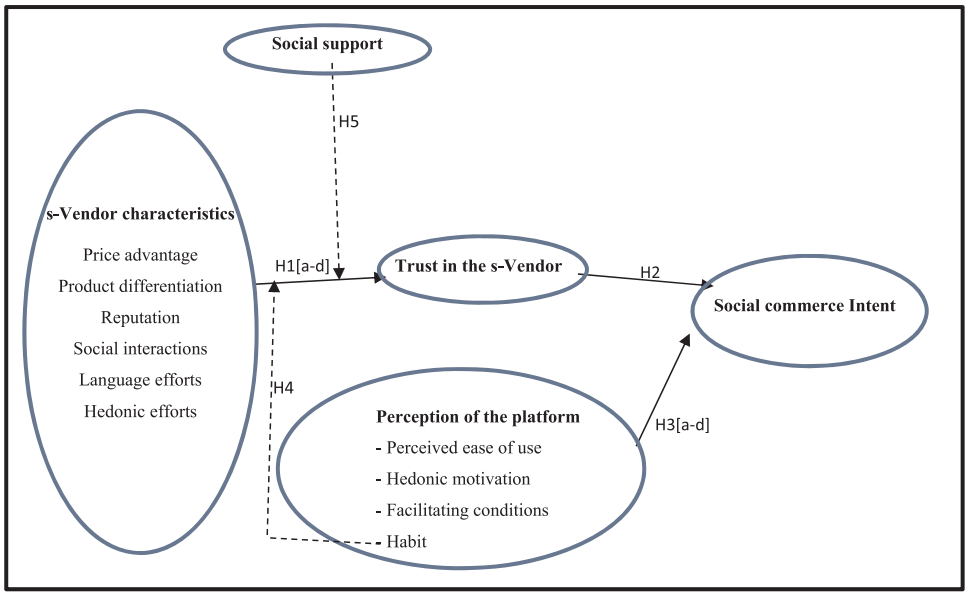


Fig. 1. The proposed research model.

adopt and use the platform for online shopping.

Consequently, this research aims to align the business strategy with the social media platform strategy to understand the mechanism of social commerce. For this purpose, it investigates the effects of the perceived characteristics of the s-vendors on trust and social commerce while drawing attention to the platform perceived usage and to the presence of others. The perception of the platform is approached through the UTAUT2 (Unified theory of Acceptance and Use of Technology 2) Model (Venkatesh et al., 2012). Accordingly, the research topic statement is as follows: *To what extent do the s-vendors characteristics influence trust and social commerce intent? What are the impacts of social support and the platform perceived usage?*

By investigating the mechanism of how the s-vendor characteristics influence social commerce, this research can help scholars to understand the role of social media for consumer behavior and marketing and help businesses improve their current social commerce operations.

To answer our research questions, this paper is organized as follows. First, it begins with a brief literature review of trust. Second, it develops the conceptual framework and details the research methodology. Third, it deals with the analysis and discussion of the findings. Finally, the conclusion covers the implications, limitations, and future research options.

1.1. Trust in online contexts

Trust is a concept studied in different disciplines such as philosophy, economics, sociology, management, and marketing (Corritore et al., 2003; Blois, 1999; Rousseau et al., 1998). Trust is a crucial issue in online shopping environments, but it is more important in social commerce platforms where uncertainty is higher due to the lack of face-to-face communications and the high level of user-generated content (Featherman and Hajli, 2015). Schurr and Ozanne (1985) defined trust as one's confidence on the exchange party's capability and willingness to establish the business' adherence to the relationship norms and keeping promises. According to Suh and Han (2003, p. 137), trust is the sense of trusting beliefs, referring to the beliefs that "*one can rely upon a promise made by another and that the other, in unforeseen circumstances, will act toward oneself with goodwill and in a benign fashion*". Ba and Pavlou (2002) posited that *trust is an individual's belief that an exchange will occur in a manner consistent with one's confident expectations*. In online contexts, trust is based on beliefs in the trustworthiness of an exchange party (McKnight et al., 2002). According to Lin (2011), trustworthiness is related to the perceptions of competence, benevolence, and integrity. Compared to trustworthiness, trust involves other additional personality- and environment-related factors (McKnight et al., 1998). However, in marketing research, trust and trustworthiness are used interchangeably (Blois, 1999).

Trust is viewed as a unidimensional or a multidimensional concept (Gefen, 2002). Some authors conceive this latter as a multidimensional construct (Aiken and Boush, 2006; Bart et al., 2005). However, most researchers opted for a unidimensional perspective that seems to be quite satisfactory (Hajli et al., 2017; Pappas, 2016; Hajli, 2014a, 2014b; Pavlou and Fygenson, 2006; Everard and Galletta, 2005; Jarvenpaa et al., 2000).

1.2. Conceptual framework

Social commerce refers to "*exchange-related activities that occur in, or are influenced by, an individual's social network in computer-mediated social environments, where the activities correspond to the need of recognition, pre-purchase, purchase, and post-purchase stages of a focal exchange*" (Yadav et al., 2013, p. 312). To Kim and Park (2013), social commerce is "*a subset of e-commerce and it uses SNSs for social interactions and user contributions to facilitate the online buying, and selling of various products and services*. Researchers have identified customers as the main driving force in the social commerce movement. These customers are opinion seekers (Kang and Johnson, 2013). They are looking for more customized, informative and engaging shopping experiences (Zhou et al., 2013). They seek the best prices by engaging with social media platforms to make informed purchasing decisions (Kim and Park, 2012). That is where social commerce comes into play. Customers can seek and find the information they need in a social commerce platform through posted ratings and reviews, recommendations and referrals (Hajli, 2015). This additionally promotes a higher level of trust between the users (Ba and Pavlou, 2002).

As explained by prior research on interpersonal trust (Gefen, 2000), trust arises from the attributes associated with the trustee (Mayer et al., 1995). It is determined by the trustor's perception of the characteristics of the trustee. The proposed conceptual model relies upon those studies to postulate that trust has a mediating role between the s-vendor characteristics and social commerce intent. The following paragraphs describe in detail the suggested conceptual framework (Fig. 1).

1.3. S-Vendor characteristics

Kim and Park (2013) identified several social commerce

characteristics as key antecedents of trust: reputation, size, information quality, transaction safety, communication, economic feasibility, and word-of-mouth referrals. Jarvenpaa et al. (2000) noted the seller must have the ability and the motivation to meet consumer expectations in a reliable manner in order to develop trust. Trust must be more difficult to harvest online than offline.

To have a deeper understanding of the s-vendor characteristics, a qualitative study was carried out. The purpose is to confirm and to complete the literature review as well as, possibly identify factors that may affect social commerce. Given that social media platforms have different characteristics and operating (Hajli et al., 2017; Kim and Park, 2013), interviews with Instagram users were conducted to narrow down the context and reduce the effects of the platform choice. Instagram is a very popular platform worldwide. A recent survey in the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) countries showed that Facebook is completely ignored in favor of Instagram. For instance, only one in five Qataris use Facebook, but more rely on Instagram (22% Facebook vs. 60% Instagram) (Dennis et al., 2016).

Interviewees are users from GCC countries. They were asked about the reasons and the criteria considered when buying from s-vendors on Instagram. The interviews started, first, with a general question of what is considered when buying from Instagram. Then, few topics related to functional, emotional, and hedonist features of the s-vendor were discussed. Theoretical saturation was noticed after ten (10) interviews. The content analysis was performed manually. Six (06) dimensions emerged: **the price advantage** (the vendor *offers the items at a lower price than the ones found in retail stores)*; **the differentiation of the product** (*the vendor offers products that I can't find elsewhere.*" …"*He also offers products that are in limited edition and therefore unique*); **the reputation** ("*Everyone buys from him. I asked my friends and they recommended this vendor. Reviews are good about him on Instagram……"Yes. If I see more followers I believe that he has many satisfied customers*""); **social interactions** (*the vendor is quick to reply to questions when in doubt… There are two things that I like about the vendor. He informs the followers that he will bring new items… He tells us about the quantity sold which shows if other people bought the product)*; **language efforts** (*the best thing is that the vendor makes effort to communicate in different language.*), and **hedonic efforts** (*Sometimes I get bored form all the products he is listing. I appreciate seeing something else funny…I love games and tombola*).

After qualitative pretests, the set of items (Table 1) were analyzed using Principal Component Analysis and then Confirmatory Analysis and they both confirmed the good quality of the scale.

Previous studies on e-commerce have largely discussed the importance of the website characteristics and have shown that an e-vendor's characteristics play important role in the formation of consumers' trust. Kim and Park (2013) and Jarvenpaa et al. (2000) found significant positive relationship between reputation and trust. Oh et al. (2006) found that price advantage and product differentiation increase the level of consumers' trust in online firms. Similarly, Lu et al. (2006) demonstrated that price advantage, derived from discounts, fosters consumers' trust online. Moorman et al. (1992) claimed that active communication between consumers and firms increases consumers' trust. Likewise, Liao et al. (2006) and Kim and Park (2013) found that communicating and providing information about products and services increase the trustworthiness of e-commerce. According to Kim and Park (2013), communication may play a more important role in s-commerce than in other types of e- commerce. De Wulf et al. (2001) emphasized that the perceived seller efforts foster consumers trust and engagements. Those works rely on the principle of the relationship marketing stipulating that companies' efforts create a feeling of gratefulness. Likewise, we postulate that the s-vendor characteristics, identified thanks to the literature review and the qualitative study, influence trust. Consequently, we formulate the following hypothesis (through its sub-blocs H1a–H1f).

H1a. The s-vendor price advantage positively influences users' trust.

H1b. The s-vendor reputation positively influences users' trust.

H1c. The s-vendor products differentiation positively influences users' trust.

H1d. Social interactions with the s-vendor positively influence users' trust.

H1e. The s-vendor language efforts positively influence users' trust.

H1f. The s-vendor hedonic efforts positively influence users' trust.

1.4. Social commerce intent

Previous research had demonstrated that customers' intent to shop is highly dependent on the customers' perception of trust (Kang and Johnson, 2013). The problem of trust would not arise if all partners were moral (Jarvenpaa et al., 1998). Previous literature has also largely shown that the purchase from an e-vendor depends on customer's trust in the e-vendor (Hajli et al., 2017; Lu et al., 2016). Studies conducted in this area have especially highlighted the mediating effect of online trust on the relationship between website atmospherics and behavioral intentions (Bart et al., 2005; Everard and Galletta, 2005; Gefen and Straub, 2004). Kim and Park (2013) indicated that users who trust social commerce sites are more likely to purchase on these platforms. Trust facilitates indeed engaging in financial transactions (Everard and Galletta, 2005) and overcomes psychological barriers related to online purchase (Pavlou and Fygenson, 2006). In line with these studies, we assume that trust in the s-vendor increases the intent to shop. The following hypothesis is, therefore, formulated:

H2. Trust in the s-vendor influences positively users' social commerce intent.

1.5. The platform perceived usage

One of the most popular and wide used models that aim to explain why customers use a technology over another is the UTAUT model, which was developed by Venkatesh et al. (2003), and improved by Venkatesh et al. (2012). The original UTAUT is composed of four core components that are effort expectancy, social influence, performance expectancy and facilitating conditions. Venkatesh et al. (2012) revisited the original theory and developed the UTAUT 2 by adding hedonic motivation, price value, and habits. UTAUT 2 model adopts an integrative perspective and has an increased explanatory power in comparison with other technology adoption models (Venkatesh et al., 2012). Initially, the UTAUT model was developed to describe the acceptance and use of technology. Subsequently, it was applied to many other contexts, such as e-banking and many industries that develop applications and services of technology that target consumers. We assume that this model can be useful to understand the adoption of a social media platform for social commerce. Escobar-Rodríguez and Carvajal-Trujillo (2013) mobilized the UTAUT model to understand consumer purchase of website airline tickets. Similarly, Lian and Yen (2014) used it to understand the drivers for online shopping.

Based on this theory, we assume that the perceived ease of use of the platform for social commerce; the perceived hedonic motivation (the pleasure or entertainment when buying on the platform); the facilitating conditions (users' perceptions of the resources and support available to perform social commerce) and habit (the extent to which users tend to perform shopping automatically because of learning) may be relevant to understand the adoption of the platform for social commerce activities.

Pahnila et al. (2011) demonstrated that, facilitating conditions have direct influence on behavioral intention. According to the research conducted by Nasir (2013), Jati and Laksito (2012), Venkatesh et al. (2012), and Pahnila et al. (2011), ease of use has direct influence on

Table 1
Items and Reliability of the conceptual model variables.

Dimension	Item	Loadings	α de Cronbach	CR
Price advantage	PR1: The products of this vendor are reasonably priced.	0.922	0.857	0.94
	PR2: The products of this vendor are a good value for the money.	0.916		
	PR3: The product prices are cheaper than the ones found elsewhere.	0.877		
Trust	TRS1: This vendor would be trustworthy	0.957	0.941	0.962
	TRS2: This vendor site could be trusted	0.951		
	TRS3: This vendor would be honest and truthful to me	0.93		
Product differentiation	Diff1: This vendor offers products that I cannot find elsewhere	0.602	0.738	0.93
	Diff2: This vendor gives me the opportunity to get unique products	0.855		
Reputation	REP1: This vendor has many followers	0.755	0.822	0.884
	REP2: This vendor receives many likes on his products	0.782		
	REP3: This vendor is recommended by my friends on Instagram	0.855		
	REP6: Reviews are good about this vendor	0.846		
Social interactions with the vendor	SI1: My interaction with the vendor on Instagram is clear and understandable	0.808	0.718	0.94
	SI2: The vendor communicates frequently with followers	0.8		
	SI3: The vendor replies to my comments and questions	0.979		
Language efforts	AE1: This vendor makes effort to write his posts in my home language	0.8	0.877	0.861
	AE2: This vendor cares about the home language of his followers	0.862		
Hedonic efforts	EE1: The vendor posts general tips about his products	0.84	0.754	0.859
	EE2: The vendor offers free giveaway	0.814		
	EE3: The vendor has enjoyable posts	0.802		
Habit	HA1: Using Instagram for buying has become a habit for me	0.891	0.843	0.90
	HA2: Using Instagram for buying has become natural to me.	0.862		
	HA3: I am addicted to the buy on Instagram	0.867		
Perceived ease of use	EU1: Buying from Instagram is easy for me.	0.957	0.908	0.956
	EU2: I find buying from Instagram easy to use.	0.957		
Social commerce intent	Int1: I intend to buy from this vendor in the future	0.96	0.954	0.965
	Int2: I am willing to buy from this vendor in the future	0.957		
	Int3: I plan to buy from this vendor in the future	0.932		
Social support	SS1: When faced with difficulties, my friends on the Instagram comforted and encouraged me.	0.91	0.833	0.900
	SS2: My friends on Instagram would offer suggestions when I needed help.	0.852		
	SS3: When I encountered a problem, my friends on Instagram would help me overcome the problem.	0.836		
Hedonic motivation	HM11: Using Instagram to buy is funny.	0.965	0.949	0.967
	HM12: Buying on Instagram is enjoyable	0.951		
	HM13: Buying on Instagram is entertaining	0.943		
Facilitating conditions	FC1: Buying on Instagram is compatible with other technologies I use	0.875	0.7	0.867
	FC2: I have the resources necessary to buy on Instagram	0.875		

behavioral intention. Research conducted by Venkatesh et al. (2012) and Escobar-Rodríguez and Carvajal-Trujillo (2013) showed that habit and hedonic motivation have direct effect against behavioral intention. In line with those studies, the following hypotheses are formulated:

H3a. Ease of use positively influences social commerce intent.

H3b. Hedonic motivation positively influences social commerce intent.

H3c. Facilitating conditions are positively related to social commerce intent.

H3d. Habit positively influences social commerce intent.

Further, we think that habit may affect the impact of the s-vendor's characteristics on trust. In other words, the more the user is used to buy on the platform, the less he will be sensitive to the s-vendor's characteristics. Recently, Van Der Heide and Lim (2015) indicated that users who are familiar with a platform are more likely to rely on generated contents by their peers and consequently less likely on the business strategy. Similarly, we assume that, being used to the platform operating, the consumer may feel less impressed by the s-vendor's characteristics. Consequently, the following hypothesis, H4 is formulated:

H4. Habits weakens the relationships between the s-vendor characteristics and trust.

1.6. Social support

In virtual environments, social support may refer to mutual help that can help to solve problems directly and indirectly thanks to the provision of information, experiences and advice; and to emotional concerns such as care, encouragements or empathy (Romaniuk, 2012). We think that this support may enhance trust in the other users, which may encourage people to be more open to business strategies and more likely to trust them. Researchers have mostly described the networks people take part in when investigating trust (Abbott and Freeth, 2008). It is important to examine how the individuals perceive their networks. In high social support groups, trust could potentially be easily formed, first of all, because the members rely on mutual help. Shopping has always been a social experience and social networks allow consumers to interact with others. Zhang et al. (2014) suggested that increasing social support and encouraging mutual help among customers would foster a supportive environment for social commerce. Consequently, the following hypothesis, H5, is formulated:

H5. Social support positively influences the relationship between the s-vendor characteristics and trust.

2. Methodology

To test the conceptual model, all the following seven (07) scale measures were obtained from previous studies: **trust** (Jarvenpaa et al., 2000), **behavioral intentions** (Venkatesh et al., 2003), **social support** (Hajli, 2014a, 2014b; Lal, 2017); **hedonic motives**, **ease of use**, **facilitating conditions** and **habit** (Venkatesh et al., 2012). Given the context of social commerce, the original items were slightly adjusted by marketing researchers familiar with social media and social commerce research. Finally, all the items of the questionnaire were evaluated and the content validated by the social media users.

As mentioned before, the s-vendor characteristics stem out from the literature review and from a qualitative study. Initially, we started with twenty-one (21) items. A first survey was conducted to ensure the

Table 2
AVE and square of correlations between the model variables.

	Reputation.	Price advantage	Hedonic efforts	Lang. efforts	Product differentiation	S.commerce intent	Trust	Facilitating conditions	Ease of use	Habits	Hedonic motivations	S. Interactions with the s-vendor
Reputation	**0.65**											
Price advantage	0.214	**0.819**										
Hedonic efforts	0.130	0.235	**0.67**									
Language efforts	0.070	0.054	0.223	**0.690**								
Product differentiation.	0.104	0.259	0.033	0.002	**0.590**							
S-commerce Intent	0.152	0.243	0.052	0.033	0.051984	**0.9**						
Trust	0.154	0.129	0.018	0.081	0.011564	0.6658	**0.89**					
Facilitating Conditions	0.017	0.010	0.011	0.097	0.000844	0.0595	0.1162	**0.76**				
Ease of use	0.019	0.053	0.028	0.048	0.010658	0.2079	0.1980	0.245025	**0.91**			
Habits	0.003	0.014	0.064	0.043	0.002923	0.1169	0.1030	0.090601	0.19624	**0.76**		
Hedonic motivations	0.033	0.150	0.041	0.068	0.0361	0.1317	0.1056	0.094249	0.36240	0.3410	**0.9**	
S-Interactions with the s-vendor	0.227	0.343	0.452	0.012	0.0625	0.2621	0.2420	0.044944	0.05616	0.0201	0.065025	**0.75**

Notes: Numbers on the diagonal (in boldface) are the average variance extracted. Other numbers are the square of correlations.

quality of the scale. After performing principal component analysis, the initial results showed that 68.39% of the data are explained by nine (09) factors. Further purification of the items based on their saturation on the different factors was performed. In the final structure, the results highlighted six (06) factors which explain 66.21% of the data. The Kaiser Meyer Olkin (KMO) value was 0.80 and is well over the required minimum (Hutcheson and Sofroniou, 1999). Bartlett's test is also significant ($p < 0.001$). Therefore, a factor analysis is appropriate which we conducted using a Varimax rotation with Kaiser normalization. Convergence of the rotation was achieved after six (06) iterations. The Cronbach's Alpha measure of internal consistency and reliability of the factors was satisfactory (Nunnally, 1978). The conducted confirmatory analyses approved the good quality of the scale (Table 2).

Survey Monkey was used to develop the final online questionnaire that was administrated to Instagram users with different demographics. We chose not to recourse to a student population, often used in such studies to avoid any representativeness bias in the results limiting their generalization (Jarvenpaa et al., 2000). The scale measures were chosen as rating questions with a weight ranging from 1 to 5 corresponding respectively to “Completely Disagree”, “Disagree”, “Neutral”, “Agree” and “Completely Agree”. The questionnaire was administrated through Whats’App Application, Instagram, Twitter, and Facebook. Before proceeding with the data analysis, an initial data screening was performed on 299 responses for missing values and outliers. After cleaning the data of outlier points, 205 cases were usable. Kolmogorov-Smirnov and Shapiro-Wilk tests were significant proving the normality of data. 64.9% of the respondents were male and 35.1%female. 53.4% of the respondents were in the age range 25–35. Among the respondents, 63.2% are employees, 28.4% are students, 0.7% are pupils, and the rest are from other socio-professional categories (7.7%). For their Instagram use, 24.6% of the respondents use it more than 3 h a day, 44.1% between 1 and 3 h a day, and 31.3% for less than one hour a day.

3. Results

3.1. Assessment of the measurement Model

Structural Equation Modeling (SEM) using AMOS 24 are selected for this study in order to test simultaneously all the relationships between the model variables (Hair et al., 2009). Conforming to the accepted procedure for Confirmatory Factor Analysis, (CFA), and SEM, (Davis et al., 2017; Bagozzi and Yi, 2012; Gerbing and Anderson, 1992), a first step was to conduct a Principal Factor Analysis (PCA) and a CFA on all variables. Then a SEM was conducted on the whole model. Cronbach Alphas and Composite Reliability scores (CR) were used to assess the reliability and internal validity of all scales. Consequently, some items were removed. All Cronbach alphas and composite reliability values are higher than 0.70 (Naylor et al., 2012). The convergent validity was assessed through three steps. First, all item loadings were higher than 0.5. Second, the Composite Reliabilities were higher than 0.70 (Naylor et al., 2012) (Table 1). Third, all AVE values exceeded 0.50. In addition, the squares of the correlations among the constructs were lower than the corresponding AVEs, which indicates satisfactory discriminant validity (Chin, 1998) (Table 2).

3.2. Assessment of the structural model

To test the model, SEM was performed. The model fit was acceptable at TLI 0.881; CMIN/DF 1.983; RMSEA 0.06; CFI 0.901; IFI 0.902; NFT 0.82. RMSEA and CFI are less sensitive to the sample size (Fan et al., 1999).

The results (Table 3) show that reputation, price advantage, language and hedonic efforts have significant positive effects on trust. However, social interaction and product differentiation decrease trust. Consequently (H1a; H1b; H1e and H1f are validated while H1c and H1d are reversed.

In addition, effects of trust, ease of use, hedonic motives, facilitating conditions and habit on social commerce intent are significant. Those results corroborate H2 and the bloc H3[a–d].

3.3. Testing the moderating effects

Previous research has mostly used SEM to test linear models. Multiple group analyses in SEM require, indeed, strong assumptions. Jöreskog and Yang (1996) explained that very large samples are needed and complex constraints must be posed when specifying models. Bagozzi and Yi ((2012) added that the use of SEM will not give correct results unless one has a sufficiently large sample. Given the relatively small sample of this study, regressions with interactions effects were performed on SPSS 24 in order to test the moderating effects of social support and habit (Tables 4 and 5).

Table 3
Results of the structural model.

Relationship			Estimate	S.E.	C.R.	P	
Trust	< –	Reputation	1.599	0.425	9.765	***	H1b accepted
Trust	< –	S_Interactions	− 3.760	1.208	− 3.111	0.043	H1d reversed
Trust	< –	Price Advantage	1.778	0.428	4.149	***	H1a accepted
Trust	< –	Language Efforts	0.469	0.197	2.383	0.017	H1e accepted
Trust	< –	Hedonic efforts	0.743	0.91	2.550	***	H1f accepted
Trust	< –	Product differentiation	− 0.837	0.348	− 2.407	0.016	H1c reversed
Intention	< –	Trust	1.538	0.116	13.289	***	H2 accepted
Intention	< –	Perceived ease	0.223	0.054	4.166	***	H3a accepted
Intention	< –	Facilitating conditions	0.397	0.049	8.063	***	H3c accepted
Intention	< –	Hedonic motives	0.087	0.036	2.402	0.016	H3b accepted
Intention	< –	Habit	0.045	0.053	2.576	0.026	H3d accepted
REP6	< –	Reputation	1.000				
REP3	< –	Reputation	0.992	0.126	7.879	***	
REP2	< –	Reputation	1.079	0.114	9.457	***	
REP1	< –	Reputation	1.247	0.130	9.581	***	
PR3	< –	Price ad.	1.000				
PR1	< –	Price ad.	1.304	0.115	11.299	***	
PR2	< –	Price ad.	1.300	0.117	11.136	***	
SI2	< –	Int with the s-vendor	1.000				
SI1	< –	Int with the s-vendor	0.975	0.131	7.472	***	
ENJOY1	< –	Hed. efforts	1.000				
ENJOY2	< –	Hed. effots	1.381	0.168	8.220	***	
Diff2	< –	P.differentiation	1.186	0.180	6.594	***	
Diff1	< –	P.differentiation	1.000				
TRS1	< –	Trust	1.000				
TRS2	< –	Trust	0.983	0.038	25.761	***	
TRS3	< –	Trust	0.941	0.047	20.038	***	
INT1	< –	S. C. Intent	1.077	0.050	21.632	***	
SI3	< –	Int with the s-vendor	1.266	0.162	7.807	***	
ENJOY3	< –	Hed. efforts	0.974	0.131	7.418	***	
LANG1	< –	Language efforts	1.000				
LANG2	< –	Language efforts	1.001	0.089	11.182	***	
INT3	< –	S. C. Intent	1.048	0.047	22.475	***	
INT2	< –	S. C. Intent	1.000				
FA1	< –	Facili_cond	1.000				
FA2	< –	Facili_cond	1.209	0.161	7.516	***	
HM1	< –	Hedonic mot	1.000				
HM2	< –	Hedonic mot	1.145	0.048	24.013	***	

Relationship			Estimate	S.E.	C.R.	P
HM3	< –	Hedonic mot	1.117	0.054	20.788	***
HA1	< –	Habit	1.000			
HA2	< –	Habit	0.995	0.086	11.567	***
HA3	< –	Habit	0.917	0.077	11.924	***
EU1	< –	Ease of use	1.091	0.064	17.134	***
EU2	< –	Ease of use	1.000			

Table 4
Moderating effect of social support.

		B	Bêta	t	sig
1	(Constant)	,033		,644	,520
	Reputation	,408	,408	7644	,000
	social interactions	− ,311	− ,311	6047	,000
	Price advantage	,349	,349	6677	,000
	Hedonic efforts	,139	,139	2719	,007
	Language efforts	,290	,290	5689	,000
	Product Differentiation	− ,125	− ,125	2437	,016
	Support *differentiation	− ,112	− ,111	− 2114	**,036**
	Support*price advantage	− ,099	− ,108	− 2044	**,042**
	Support*hedonic efforts	0.031	0.034	0.600	0.549
	Support*social interactions	− 0.080	− 0.087	− 1.565	0.119
	Support*reputation	− 0.037	− 0.046	− 0.817	0.415
	Support*Language efforts	0.048	0.075	1.171	0.243

Table 5
Moderating effect of Habits.

	B	Bêta	t	sig
(Constant)	,022		,458	,647
Reputation	,380	,380	7797	,000
Price advantage	,341	,341	6950	,000
Social interactions	− ,326	− ,326	6643	,000
Language efforts	,259	,259	5195	,000
Habit	,185	,185	3688	,000
Habit * reputation	− ,169	− ,179	− 3575	,000
Product differentiation	− ,102	− ,102	2090	,038
Habit * price advantage	− ,107	− ,102	− 2061	,041
Habit *hedonic efforts	0.031	0.034	0.600	0.549
Habit *social interactions	− 0.080	− 0.087	− 1.565	0.119
Habit *product differentiation	− 0.037	− 0.046	− 0.817	0.415
Habit *language efforts	0.048	0.075	1.171	0.243

The results show that social support has a significant negative moderating effect on the relationships between products differentiation and trust and between price advantage and trust. The moderating effect on the relationships between trust and the other characteristics is not significant. Thus, H5 is partially reversed. Similarly, the moderating effect of habit is significant only on the impacts of price advantage and reputation on trust. Therefore, H4 is partially supported.

4. Discussion

In this study, we investigated various factors that influence social commerce on Instagram by developing a conceptual model. In the proposed conceptual model, four (04) broad categories were identified as s-vendor characteristics, trust, platform perception and social support. The model was empirically tested through a survey method.

First, the present study investigates the effects of **the s-vendor characteristics** on trust. For this purpose, the first step was to explore the characteristics of the s-vendor considered by the Instagram users. The study identified six (06) criteria, which are: reputation, price advantage, social interactions, products differentiation, language and hedonic efforts. The second step was to test the effects of those characteristics on trust. Actually, there is still no agreement in previous studies about the impacts of the s-vendor characteristics on trust. In our research, findings show that reputation, price advantage, language and hedonic efforts were positively related to the trust in the s-vendor. Price advantage and reputation have the strongest positive impacts on trust. Kim and Park (2013) found that reputation has the strongest effect on trust as well. However, Fisher (2010) found that recommendations and referrals, and ratings and review were not significant on users' trust of social commerce in Canada, USA UK and Iran. Unlike our results, Kim and Park (2013) found insignificant effect of the price advantage on trust. This difference may be explained by our complementary results highlighting the moderating negative effects of habit and social support on the relationship between price advantage and trust. Users who are not used to buying on the platform and have little connection with other users are more impressed, indeed, by the price advantage offered by the business, which may increase the risk related to the s-vendor and consequently weakens trust.

Our findings also demonstrate significant positive effects of hedonic and language efforts of the s-vendor on trust. These results confirm the importance of firms' efforts and investments towards their targets. Ben Yahia (2014) showed that the experiential features of virtual communities based businesses influence positively the users' perception and so the engagement in e-commerce. De Wulf et al. (2001) demonstrated that deploying efforts towards consumers enhances a feeling of gratefulness that fosters trust and consequently the behavioral intentions.

In addition, results show significant negative impact of products differentiation on trust. Kim and Park (2013) found insignificant effect of the product differentiation (reflected by the economic feasibility) on trust. Our additional result about the moderating effect of social support on this relationship may offer some insights. Indeed, connecting with others may extenuate the effect of the product differentiation on trust. The presence of others may reduce the risk related to the asymmetry of information in social media and reassure the user about his purchase. It may reduce doubt about the business and act as potential support to users who may face bad experiences.

Unexpectedly, results show a negative impact of social interactions with the s-vendor on trust. This result is different from the findings of Kim and Park (2013) who found a positive relationship between the communication with the firm and trust. Nevertheless, this finding may be explained by the specificity of Instagram as a platform to share photos and images rather than to discuss or to interact. This result may be explained by the expectation disconfirmation theory (Oliver, 1997). Indeed, users on Instagram may expect the vendor to behave in a certain manner that fits to the requirement of the platform. Comparing the s-vendor behavior to the expected behavior may lead to a disconfirmation process, which may influence negatively trust. Venkatesh et al. (2011) found a negative relationship between trusting expectations and disconfirmation for a website. This result should draw the attention of researchers and practitioners to carefully consider the platform specificity before conducting any study or fixing business tactics.

Results confirm the positive effect of **trust** on social commerce. This result is in line with Hajli (2014a, 2014b) who demonstrated that the relationship quality (trust, satisfaction and engagement) influences positively social commerce. This is also in line with the prior studies conducted by Chen and Shen (2015) and Ng (2013), where trust was identified as significant in influencing customers' purchase intention through social commerce websites.

Finally, the findings show that the effects of **the platform perceived usage** (ease of use, facilitating conditions, habits and hedonic motivation) on social commerce are significant. Facilitating conditions and ease of use have the strongest effects on social commerce. This result confirms the necessity to think about the platform characteristics and readiness before launching any activity and underlines the importance to choose the platform that fits most to the business strategy. This result is in line with previous studies conducted by Ye et al. (2016) and Zhang et al. (2016) where the characteristics of the website were statistically significant in adoption of online services. This result is in line, as well, with previous research that confirmed the relevance of the UTAUT model in explaining new technology adoption.

4.1. Theoretical insights and business implications

At a theoretical level, this article sheds light on the mechanism of social commerce in social media. The study draws attention to the necessity of considering the platform specificity when investigating social media. Unlike other forms of e-commerce channels, findings show, for instance, that the social interactions with Instagram vendors have negative effect on trust. Moreover, the ease of the platform use and the facilitating conditions increase social commerce.

Furthermore, the study helps to understand the effects of the s-vendor characteristics on trust and explains the contradictory results of previous research by shedding light on the moderating effects of habits and social support. In this line, this research confirms the important role of social support in social media platforms.

At a practical level, firms in social commerce need to adjust their business strategies to face the challenges of the rapid growth of social media. Based on our findings, businesses should focus on setting competitive and reasonable prices to build their reputation and secure customer trust. This can be achieved by comparing their prices with competitors on social media, in the local market, or with e-commerce websites to offer prices that are more appealing. However, given that the effect of the price advantage on trust is sensitive to the habit of buying on the platform, firms may focus more on the other characteristics such as reputation, language and hedonic efforts that foster trust and consequently their intent to shop.

Last but not least, firms have to understand and to be attentive to the specificity of the platform Instagram as a medium of sharing shots rather than sharing information and posts. Instagram is built on the principle of sharing pictures and videos with friends or, as the company would call it on its official website,"*we're building Instagram to allow you to experience moments in your friends' lives through pictures as they happen*"(Instagram Team, 2015). Compared to other social media platforms, Instagram is mainly focused on the ease and simplicity of sharing visual media from smartphones. Firms are not expected to interact with users on Instagram. However, they may share images and videos about their offerings, which fits to the platform usage; and they may foster social interactions between users. This is a key finding for businesses especially that social support extenuate the perceived risk of the offer differentiation as well. Favoring an environment that fosters social support between customers enhance trust and social commerce.

To conclude, we recommend to think carefully about the social media platform and its requirements and perception before launching any business strategy. Aligning the business strategy with the social media strategy would be the best way to perform social commerce. This may explain why Facebook; Twitter or Pinterest have not demonstrated any commercial potential. Recently, Instagram introduced its 'Shop Now' feature. This new feature may improve the perceived ease of use and hedonic motivation of the platform, which may have a powerful impact on social commerce. Businesses should keep an eye on the social media platforms that offer the best conditions to launch social commerce.

4.2. Limitations and future research

Like all, there are some limitations to our study, which may provide opportunities for further research. First, the context is limited to the social media platform Instagram. The objective was to highlight the specificity of the social media platform and to call to the consideration of its perceived usage when dealing with social commerce for research or business. Future research may test the model on other platforms and further investigate how the platform type affects social commerce. In addition, the sample was limited to s-commerce users in GCC countries, and therefore the generalizability of the findings may be limited. Instagram is the most used platform in GCC, but undoubtedly, Facebook is the most used in other countries. Future research should consider s-commerce users in other countries. Third, our study is limited to the social commerce intent. Future research may investigate the real behavior of users and consider other variables that may explain any divergence between intents and the real behaviors. Future research may also identify other internal and external factors that may have effects on trust development and on customer's intentions to shop. For instance, little or no work has been undertaken to examine cultural influence on social networking. Considering the cultural background may be interesting to predict the consumer behavior on social media. Considering the consumer empowerment as well may be another interesting track to understand social commerce in social media.

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